Less > More: Five Challenges to the Dominant Aesthetics of Digital Imagery

Marloes de Valk

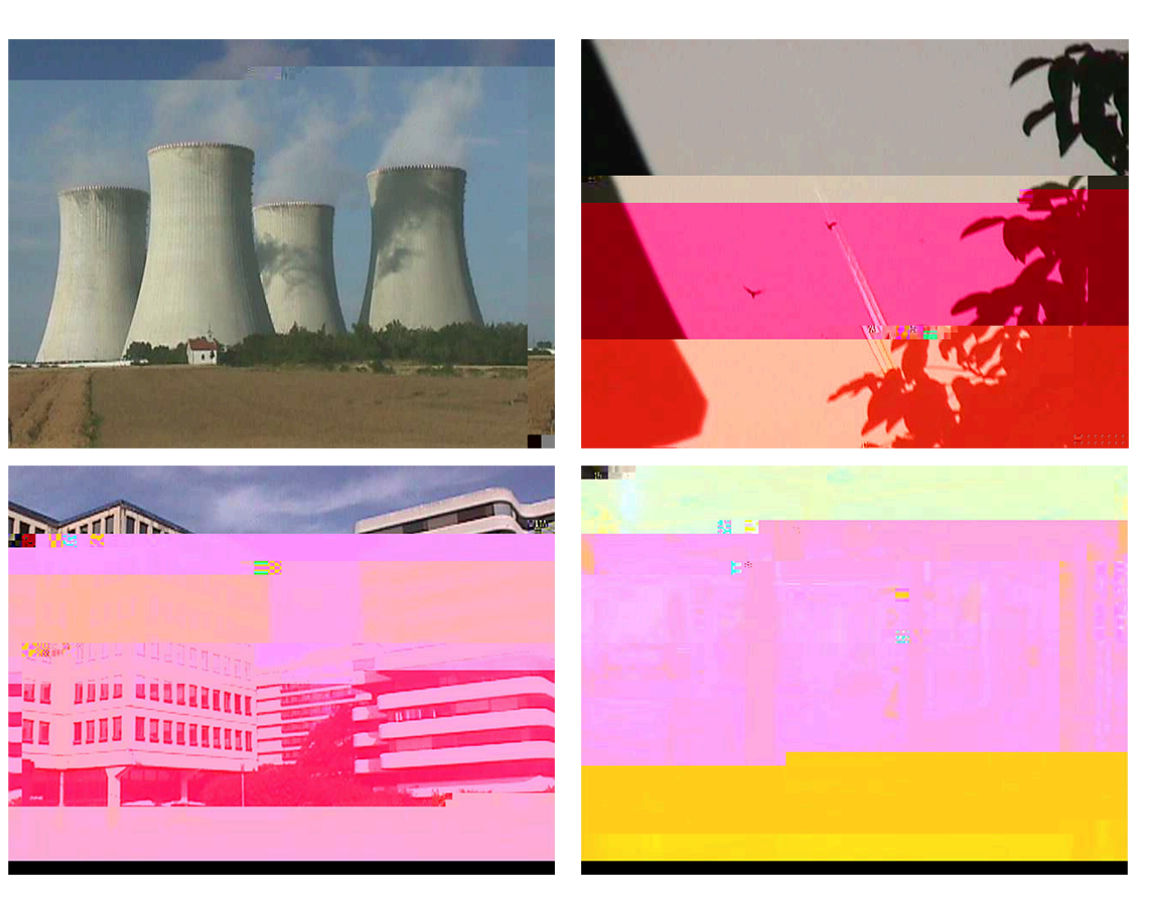
2025-11-17 ▼

The Small File Photo Festival took place at The Photographers' Gallery in January 2023. It consisted of a workshop, presentations and an award ceremony honouring creative, impressive, expressive and moving small file photographs send in response to an open call. A total of 437 works were submitted, photographs of up to 100Kb using any method to achieve a small file size. The jury created a shortlist of about 40 works, which are exhibited online Six award winners were selected.

The festival was inspired by The Small File Media Festival, an annual event, started in 2020, which celebrates small file video, film and media art. It raises awareness about the carbon footprint of streaming media and draws attention to appropriate technologies that use little bandwidth, resisting bandwidth imperialism. In this essay, **Marloes de Valk** reflects on four artists' work and suggests different ways to reject the dominant aesthetics of digital photography.

'We are looking for small file photographs! We call to overcome the high-resolution regime and propose that small is beautiful, exciting and relevant!'

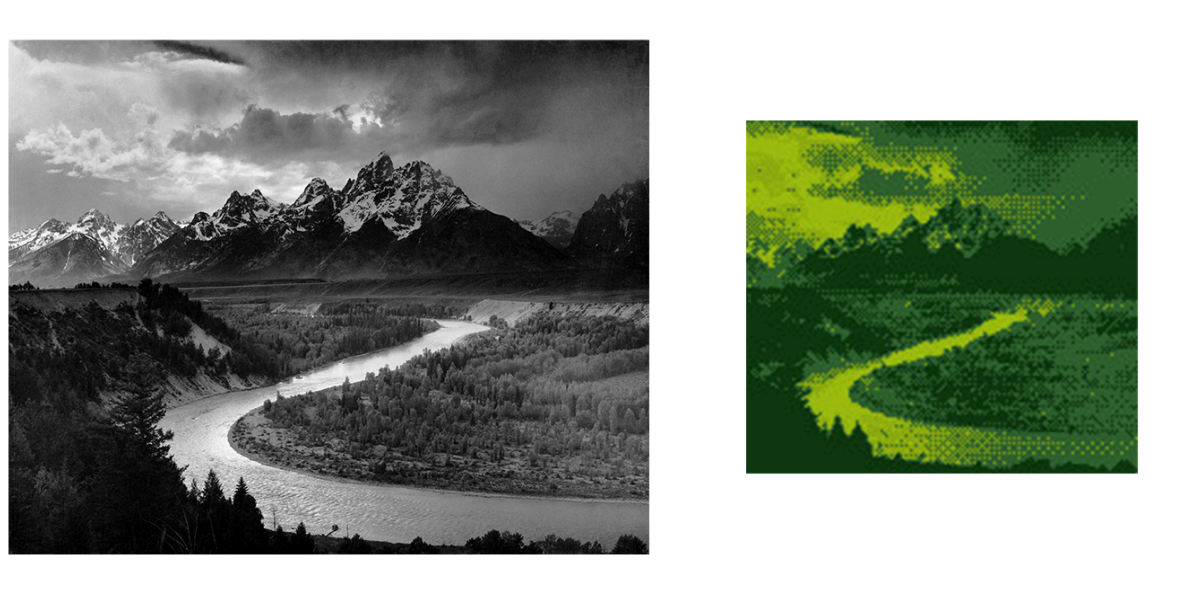
I would like to introduce you to four works that were part of the Small File Photo Festival (SFPF), an event and online exhibition that took place in January 2023 at The Photographers' Gallery. Each of the works show some of the potentials of the small image to challenge the push for ever higher resolutions, an eternal upgrading to the closest reproduction of reality possible, no matter the costs (to people or environment) or function (perceivable with the senses or not). These aesthetics result in an increase in resource consumption by creating demand for newer devices such as screens, smart phones, computers and servers, an increase in electricity consumption of those devices and upgrades in network infrastructure such as more and bigger data centres, 5G and fiber-optic networks.However serious its intentions, the event was a joyful celebration of the small image in all its shapes and forms, a humorous and rebellious act, celebrating what are generally considered 'poor' or low quality photographs, in the heart of a photography institution.



GLITCH-BORDEAUXMAVICAZINE © 2022 MAVICAZINE - RENAAT NIJS.
MAVICAZINE - Renaat Nijs.

The ***MAVICAZINE*** series by photographer Renaat Nijs won the award in the category *Show Me The Pixels*. Together with Raf Horemans, Nijs publishes *MAVICAZINE*, an ode, not just to the Mavica, but to all early digital cameras. This series was part of it, and aims to demonstrate how low resolution digital photography, even though often frowned upon, can be mesmerising. The photos were taken with a Sony Mavica MVC-FD7 Floppy Disk camera from 1997. The FD7, recording two VGA interlaced fields in 640×480 pixel JPGs, takes 10 seconds to write a 0.3 megapixel, 8 bit photo onto a floppy disk. Nijs glitched the image by physically abusing the floppy-drives with a 13" claw hammer during the writing of the file, a very unpredictable process. He calls this process 'analogue editing'.

The series challenges bandwidth imperialism by emphasising (with brute force) the materiality of the digital. Rather than betting on ephemeralisation, doing more and more with less and less, it does less and less with very little. It makes the material nature of the digital photo tangible by literally taking a hammer to it, erasing and distorting parts of it. It challenges maximalist techno-aesthetics [8], which aims for 'indistinguishable from real' high resolutions and effects, by embracing low resolution's simplification of colors and shapes. Through the abstract elements in the image, it creates a blend of photography and graphic design, an ironic but beautiful clash between modernist themes and technological glitches and failure.



Ansel Adams - The Tetons and the Snake River, 1942. Public Domain; & GameBoy Ansel Adams - Snake River Overlook 4 Kb © 2022. Courtesy Sofi Xian.

Gameboy Ansel Adams – Snake River Overlook by photographer and computational linguist Sofi Xian [9] is a dithered and modified version of Ansel Adams' *The Tetons and the Snake River*. The image was cropped and resized in Photoshop, after which it was exported as GIF using legacy web export settings with a Game Boy palette and pattern dithering enabled. Jury member Clare Strand observed the work seems to commit a type of aesthetic sacrilege; Adams is the master of the 'fine art print', obsessed with tonal and print perfection, and the fact that precisely *his* print was processed with one of the most heavy types of compression possible is quite a statement. Adams (1902-1984), whose photos of national parks and work as an environmentalist helped expand the national park system in the US, never made the connection between electronics and environmental harm. In an interview from 1983 he was quite looking forward to extremely high resolutions:

> *'There's no end in sight. [...] the time will come when you will be able to make the entire photograph electronically. With the extremely high resolution and the enormous control you can get from electronics, the results will be fantastic. I wish I were young again!' - Ansel Adams interviewed by* Vicki Sheff, *Playboy, May 1983*

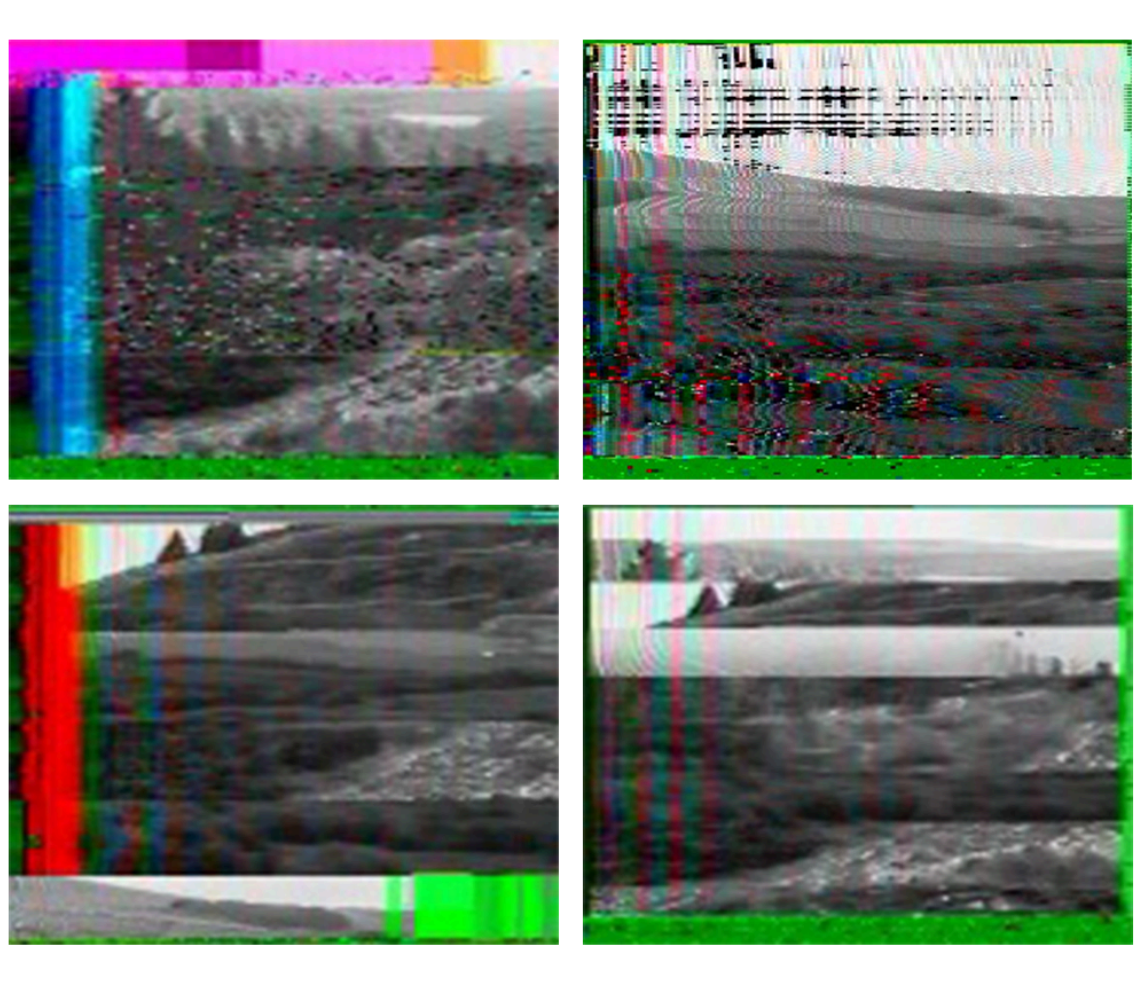
Xian's work confronts the old conservationist environmentalism of Adams, which seeks to preserve nature in designated natural parks, hoping to protect it from human intervention. Like his environmentalism, his photography also fixes, separates and conserves: it requires sharpness and amazing detail and it lends its strength from the mesmerising stillness, depth and detail of immense landscapes, untouched and uninhabited, frozen in time. Xian's work on the other hand, seems to hint at how *The Tetons and the Snake River*, no matter their status as national park, are penetrated by micro-plastics and PFAS. In her work, the medium reflects the message [10] . It engages with the inseparability of nature and culture and with technology's environmental impact. *Gameboy Ansel Adams* shows nature distorted by technology, it can travel lightly to even the least networked areas of the globe and is an expression of its own entanglement with industrial capitalism.

The medium itself isn't attributed any agency, the choice of medium simply expresses the awareness the creator has of its materiality and environmental impact. The attention given to the medium becomes part of the artwork's message.

Nika Sandler
Nika Sandler - My Nonhuman Friends. © Nika Sandler, 2021

My Nonhuman Friends is a photo series by photographer Nika Sandler. Four years ago, she lost a close feline friend. This triggered her to immerse herself in her memories of the cats in her life and reflect on their impact on her. She tried to look at, and recall, the smallest details in a catlike, far-sighted way, creating still lives with objects that remember the touches and smell of her friends. Some of the photos are taken from a cat's perspective, using a small camera attached to a cat's collar. Other photos are archival ones, taken by her, and of her, as a child. The series gives shape to a deeply felt empathy and connection explored through photography. *My Nonhuman Friends* won an award in a category created especially for this series, *Posthuman Postphotography*.

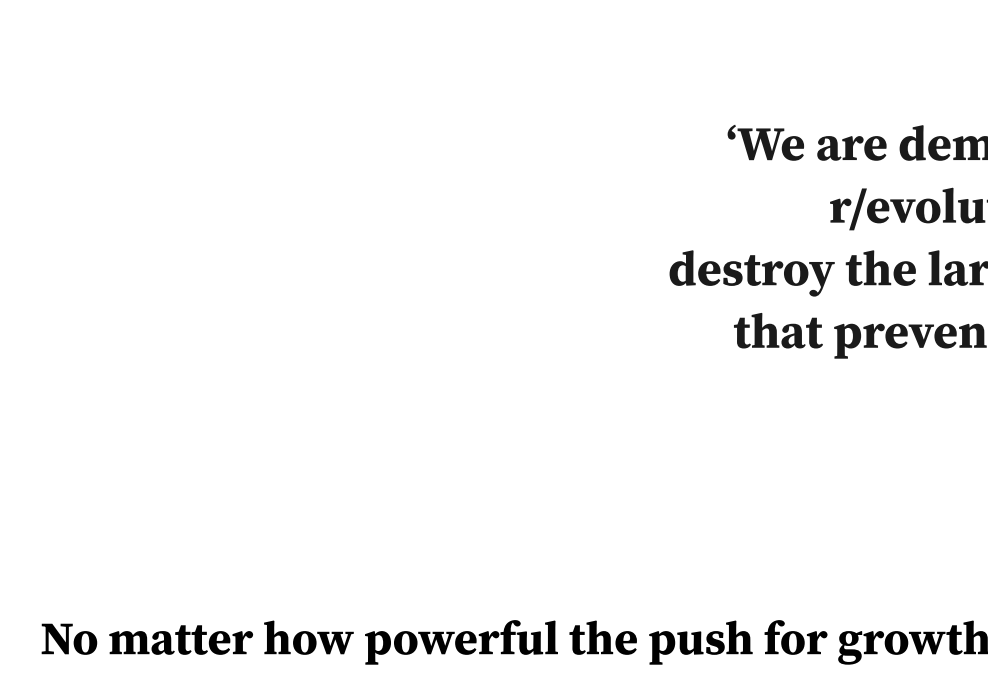
Sandler's work consists of 'poor' images, low resolution ones, taken with old or very limited cameras, shifting perspective to give expression to, and deepen a connection with the non-human. Her work matches Ingrid Hoelzl and Remi Marie's concept of the 'common image'. They describe the perspectival image as the foundation of humanist ideology, 'which located *Homo sapiens* at the center of an inanimate, dumbfounded 'world' in need of human ruling [...] a foundation of the ideology of rationality, progress, and human exceptionalism [...]'. In its stead, they propose a 'common image', which doesn't separate humans from the world, but proposes a being-in-relation. Sandler's work takes steps towards this, out of a profoundly felt love and in search of the common. In the last work this shift in perspective merges with the choice of medium.



William J. Brooks - Audible Photographs, © 2022, CC BY-NC-ND 4.0. Courtesy William J. Brooks.
William J. Brooks - Audible Photographs

William J. Brooks' work ***Audible Photographs*** is a series of 35mm photographs encoded in radio waves using slow-scan television (SSTV), an image transmission method in which an image is translated into radio signal which can be decoded back into its photographic form. It is a very slow transmission method, used to disseminate photographic information during early space exploration. Each attempt to decode a photo from the audio results in a slightly different image due to minute variations in audible reception. Ambient noise often influences the result. The images are photos taken in the Preseli Hills in Wales. *Audible Photographs* won the award in the *What's The Frequency Kenneth* category, especially created for this series.

Brook's work challenges a perspective, a way of seeing that scholar Donna Haraway has called the 'god trick', of seeing everything from nowhere, an unaccountable and disembodied perspective, distancing the knowing subject 'from everybody and everything in the interests of unfettered power.' Brooks' photos use the same transmission medium as the first photos of the whole Earth from space. Even though comparable in terms of file size, the latter puts the 'god trick' into technologically enabled practice, while the former takes an embodied and situated perspective that expresses an accountability towards what is seen through its choice of an old transmission method. Brooks takes a grounded perspective and allows the medium to be permeated by the world around, the ambient noises surrounding the receiver.



Images © Antonio Roberts, 2023
Selection of Gameboy Camera images from the Small File Photo Festival Award Ceremony, January 2023

> **'We are demanding—unleash creative r/evolution! We are demanding—destroy the large-file clichés of thinking that prevent us from imaging a world otherwise!'**
>
> – Laura U. Marks, 'Small File Media Festival'.

No matter how powerful the push for growth, there is room for experimentation with degrowth in the arena of online visual culture. The works I discussed pose five challenges to the dominant aesthetics of digital imagery.

(1) Small file aesthetics are low resolution by choice in a resistance against the promise of digital technology to render infinite growth sustainable. These images do not anticipate changing the world, they try hard not to change it too much for the worse by being small.

(2) Small file aesthetics take a situated, embodied and partial perspective, accountable towards the world depicted. Small images express an awareness of their materiality and of the interrelations between the position of the photographer, the digital artefact and the world depicted.

(3) Small file aesthetics are committed to connecting dispersed audiences, not unlike Hito Steyerl's poor image. It takes a decolonial stance in its resistance against bandwidth imperialism and aims to learn from less wired areas in the world.

(4) Small file aesthetics, in line with a situated approach to knowledge production, avoid generalisations and universal solutions. It is not about format wars, aiming at one codec to rule them all, but about inventive use of a diversity of methods, including curbing demand and supply.

(5) Small file aesthetics yearn for other worlds through a collective fabrication of alternatives.

Small file aesthetics are an aesthetics of resistance and invention. The quality of an image depends on so much more than the amount of pixels per inch; its capacity to communicate (including with people in less wired places and those using older hardware), to captivate, to enchant, to slow down and spend some time with an image, to listen to its story.

This essay is based on a chapter in the PhD thesis **'The Image at the End of the World: Communities of practice redefining technology on a damaged Earth**' *(2025).*

References ▼

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SUGGESTED CITATION:
Valk, M. (2025) 'Less > More: Five Challenges to the Dominant Aesthetics of Digital Imagery', *The Photographers' Gallery: Unthinking Photography*. Available at: https://unthinking.photography/articles/less-more

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